UK's exit.[24] These measures insulated vulnerable populations from Brexit's economic fallout and curtailed the risk of other countries following Britain's lead.

The EU also prioritized diversifying its global trade partnerships (Laffan and Telle 2023) to reduce its dependence on the UK. It advanced agreements with regional blocs like MERCOSUR (Zimmermann 2019) and bolstered cooperation on defense initiatives such as Permanent Structured Cooperation and the European Defense Fund (Sweeney and Winn 2020). These actions underscored the EU's commitment to maintaining its status as a global power and signaled its adaptability in navigating the post-Brexit landscape.

While the EU has largely maintained its cohesion and relevance after Brexit, this resilience is not costless. The EU's firm stance during negotiations may have solidified populist grievances within Britain, reinforcing narratives of EU inflexibility, though support for the EU seems to be on the upswing in the UK.[25] Additionally, populist leaders in other European countries have drawn on the rhetoric of the "Leave" campaign, criticizing the EU's handling of Brexit and leveraging it to bolster their own anti-EU platforms.

Nevertheless, the EU's capacity to weather Brexit and chart a stable path forward highlights its institutional adaptability and strategic pragmatism. Despite losing one of its largest and most influential members, the bloc largely demonstrated a collective resolve to preserve the European project in the face of populist disruption.

8.3 NATO and Erdoğan

NATO, a military alliance formed after World War II, stands as one of the most ambitious and expansive collective security pacts in history, comprising thirty-one member states. Anchored by Article V of its founding treaty, NATO operates on the principle of mutual defense: An attack against one member is considered an attack against all.

Turkish president Recep Tayyip Erdoğan has emerged as a vocal critic of NATO, frequently decrying what he sees as its elite-driven nature and the constraints it imposes on Turkish sovereignty (Destradi and Plagemann 2019). While Turkey remains a member, hosting key NATO military bases